Module 4, Lesson 4.5: Customer Inquiry Handling

The Customer Inquiry Challenge

Every business gets inquiries. They're a sign of interest, but they're also a time sink:

- The same questions arrive repeatedly
- Response time affects conversion
- Quality of response affects perception
- Volume can overwhelm your ability to respond

The businesses that win are those that respond quickly, consistently, and helpfully. AI automation makes this possible at scale.

The Customer Inquiry Spectrum

Not all inquiries are equal. Let's categorize them:

Category 1: Frequently Asked Questions (70-80% of inquiries)

These are the same questions you've answered a hundred times:

- "What are your prices?"
- "How does this work?"
- "Do you offer [service]?"
- "Can you help with [problem]?"

Automation Potential: High These can be handled almost entirely by AI with templates and knowledge bases.

Category 2: Qualified Interest (15-20% of inquiries)

These prospects have done research and have specific questions:

- “I saw you offer X. How would that work for [my specific situation]?”
- “I’m comparing you to [competitor]. What makes you different?”
- “I need [specific solution]. Can you help?”

Automation Potential: Medium AI can draft responses, but human review adds value.

Category 3: Complex or High-Value (5-10% of inquiries)

These require understanding nuance, building relationship, or handling complexity:

- Enterprise clients with custom needs
- Sensitive situations requiring empathy
- Complex problems needing expertise
- High-value prospects warranting personal attention

Automation Potential: Low AI assists with research and drafting, but human handles the interaction.

Setting Up Inquiry Automation

Inquiry Classification System

Create a classification framework:

```
## Customer Inquiry Classification

### Level 1: Auto-Response (FAQ)
Criteria:
- Question matches known pattern
- No customization needed
- Standard answer applies
- Low-risk response

Examples:
- Pricing inquiries
- Service descriptions
- Basic how-to questions
- Availability checks

Response: Automated with template

### Level 2: AI-Drafted Response (Qualified)
Criteria:
- Specific context mentioned
- Requires customization
- Standard framework applies
- Medium-risk response

Examples:
- Situation-specific questions
- Comparison requests
- Custom needs inquiry
- Follow-up questions

Response: AI drafts, human reviews and sends

### Level 3: Human-Led (Complex)
Criteria:
- High-value prospect
- Complex requirements
- Sensitive situation
- Strategic importance

Examples:
- Enterprise inquiries
- Custom projects
- Partnership proposals
- Complaints or issues
```

```
Response: Human handles, AI assists with research
```

Response Templates

Create templates for common inquiries:

```
~/.openclaw/workspace/Resources/inquiry-templates/
├── pricing-inquiry.md
├── service-description.md
├── availability-check.md
├── comparison-request.md
├── custom-project.md
└── follow-up.md
```

Pricing Inquiry Template:

```
# Pricing Inquiry Response

Subject: Re: Pricing Information

Hi [Name],

Thanks for reaching out! I'd be happy to share pricing information.

[Standard pricing explanation with options]

A few questions to help me give you a more precise quote:
- [Question 1 about their situation]
- [Question 2 about their needs]
- [Question 3 about timeline]

Would you like to schedule a brief call to discuss your specific needs? I
can give you a tailored estimate that way.

[Calendar link or scheduling CTA]

Best,
[Your name]
```

Knowledge Base

Build a knowledge base for consistent answers:

```
~/.openclaw/workspace/Resources/knowledge-base/
├── services.md
├── pricing.md
├── process.md
├── faq.md
└── competitors.md
```

services.md:

```
# Services Overview

## AI Automation Consulting

### What We Offer
- Process automation assessment
- Tool selection and implementation
- Training and support
- Ongoing optimization

### Who It's For
- Small businesses (5-50 employees)
- Teams overwhelmed with manual tasks
- Companies looking to scale without hiring
- Businesses seeking competitive advantage

### Typical Engagement
1. Discovery call (30 minutes)
2. Assessment and proposal (1 week)
3. Implementation (2-8 weeks depending on scope)
4. Training and handoff (1-2 weeks)
5. Optional ongoing support

### Pricing
- Hourly: $X/hour
- Project: Starting at $X
- Retainer: $X/month

[Continue with other services...]
```

Level 1: Automated FAQ Handling

Identifying FAQ Patterns

Your AI can learn to recognize FAQ patterns:

```
## FAQ Patterns

### Pricing Questions
- "How much do you charge?"
- "What are your prices?"
- "Do you have a price list?"
- "What's your rate?"
→ Use: pricing-inquiry.md template

### Services Questions
- "What services do you offer?"
- "What do you do?"
- "Can you help with [problem]?"
→ Use: services-overview.md template

### Process Questions
- "How does this work?"
- "What's the process?"
- "What are the steps?"
→ Use: process-explanation.md template
```

Automated Response Workflow

When an inquiry arrives:

1. **Classify:** AI identifies the inquiry type
2. **Match:** AI matches to appropriate template
3. **Customize:** AI fills in relevant details
4. **Draft:** AI creates response draft
5. **Send (FAQ):** Automatic for Level 1
6. **Queue (Others):** For human review

Example:

Incoming email:

> *Hi, I saw your website and I'm interested in your AI automation services. What do you charge?*

AI Processing:

```
📋 Inquiry Classification

Type: Pricing inquiry
Level: 1 (Auto-Response)
Confidence: High

Pattern Match: "What do you charge?" → pricing-inquiry template

Draft Response:
Hi [Name],

Thanks for reaching out! I'd be happy to share pricing information.

For AI automation consulting, I offer:

**Hourly Rate:** $X/hour
Best for: Smaller projects, troubleshooting, ongoing advice

**Project Rate:** Starting at $X
Best for: Defined projects with clear scope

**Monthly Retainer:** $X/month
Best for: Ongoing support and optimization

A few questions to help me give you a more precise quote:
- What specific tasks or processes are you looking to automate?
- How many people are on your team?
- What's your timeline for getting started?

Would you like to schedule a brief call to discuss your specific needs?
[Calendar link]

Best,
[Your name]

✅ Ready to send (Level 1 auto-response)
```

Level 2: AI-Assisted Responses

For inquiries that need customization:

Understanding Context

The AI analyzes the inquiry for context:

```
📋 Inquiry Analysis

**From:** John Smith, Operations Manager at Acme Manufacturing

**Context Indicators:**
- Company: Manufacturing (50+ employees based on LinkedIn)
- Role: Operations Manager (decision-maker level)
- Specific need: "automate our inventory tracking"
- Pain point: "spending 10+ hours/week on manual data entry"
- Timeline: "looking to start next quarter"

**Classification:** Level 2 (AI-Drafted)

**Suggested Approach:**
- Acknowledge specific situation
- Reference manufacturing experience
- Provide relevant case study
- Offer discovery call
- Include rough estimate range
```

Drafting with Context

The AI drafts a customized response:

```
📝 Draft Response

Hi John,

Thanks for reaching out. Inventory tracking automation is exactly what we
help businesses like yours implement.

Your situation—10+ hours/week on manual data entry—is common in
manufacturing, and the good news is it's highly automatable. We recently
helped a similar-sized manufacturing company reduce their inventory admin
time by 80%, saving them about 15 hours per week.

Based on what you've described, here's a rough idea of what this could look
like:

**Scope:** Inventory tracking automation including data capture,
reconciliation, and reporting
**Timeline:** Typically 4-6 weeks to implement
**Investment:** Projects like this generally run $X-$Y depending on
complexity

I'd love to learn more about your current process and specific needs. Would
you be open to a 30-minute call this week to discuss?

[Calendar link with suggested times]

Best,
[Your name]

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📊 Draft Stats:
- Personalization level: High
- Included case study: Yes
- Call to action: Discovery call
- Confidence: Medium-High

⚠️ Human Review Recommended
Reason: Potential high-value lead, consider personal touches
```

Human Review Queue

Level 2 responses go to a review queue:

```
📬 Response Queue (5 pending)

1. John Smith - Manufacturing inquiry (HIGH PRIORITY)
   Draft ready, 15 minutes old

2. Sarah Jones - Service comparison (MEDIUM)
   Draft ready, 1 hour old

3. Mike Brown - Follow-up question (MEDIUM)
   Draft ready, 2 hours old

[...]
```

You can:

- Approve and send as-is
- Edit and send
- Request a new draft with specific changes
- Escalate to Level 3

Level 3: Human-Led with AI Assist

For complex or high-value inquiries, the human leads, AI assists:

AI Research Support

Before you respond, the AI provides research:

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📋 Lead Intelligence: [Company/Person]

**Company Overview:**
- Industry: [Industry]
- Size: [Employee count]
- Location: [Location]
- Founded: [Year]

**Recent News:**
- [News item 1]
- [News item 2]

**Contact Background:**
- Role: [Title]
- Previous roles: [Notable positions]
- Likely priorities: [Based on role/industry]

**Potential Pain Points:**
- [Pain point 1]
- [Pain point 2]

**Competitors They May Be Considering:**
- [Competitor 1]
- [Competitor 2]

**Suggested Talking Points:**
- [Point 1]
- [Point 2]

**Similar Clients We've Helped:**
- [Case study 1]
- [Case study 2]
```

Draft Assistance

You write the response, AI helps:

“Draft a response to this inquiry. Key points to cover: [your points]”

The AI creates an initial draft that you then personalize significantly.

Follow-Up Support

After you send a response:

“Remind me to follow up with [Name] in 3 days if I don’t hear back.”

“Track this conversation and let me know if they don’t respond within a week.”

Response Quality Standards

Response Time Targets

```
## Response Time Standards

### Level 1 (FAQ)
- Target: Under 1 hour
- Acceptable: Under 4 hours
- After hours: First thing next business day

### Level 2 (Qualified)
- Target: Under 4 hours
- Acceptable: Same business day
- After hours: First thing next business day

### Level 3 (Complex/High-Value)
- Target: Same business day
- Acceptable: Within 24 hours
- Always aim for fastest reasonable response
```

Quality Checklist

Before any response goes out:

```
## Response Quality Checklist

### Content
- [ ] Answers the question asked
- [ ] Provides relevant next step
- [ ] Includes appropriate detail
- [ ] Addresses their specific situation

### Tone
- [ ] Professional but approachable
- [ ] Helpful, not salesy
- [ ] Appropriate for inquiry level

### Mechanics
- [ ] No spelling/grammar errors
- [ ] Correct name and details
- [ ] Working links
- [ ] Appropriate subject line

### Follow-Up
- [ ] Clear call to action
- [ ] Follow-up scheduled if needed
- [ ] Added to CRM/tracking
```

Handling Difficult Inquiries

Complaints or Issues

These always require human attention:

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## Complaint Handling Protocol

1. Acknowledge immediately
2. Take seriously
3. Don't be defensive
4. Investigate the issue
5. Respond with solution
6. Follow up to ensure satisfaction

AI Role:
- Draft acknowledgment email
- Research the customer's history
- Find relevant policies or precedents
- Suggest resolution options
- Track follow-up
```

Unusual Requests

For inquiries that don't fit templates:

"This doesn't fit our standard categories. Draft a thoughtful response asking clarifying questions so I can help them better."

Out of Scope

For inquiries outside your services:

"They're asking about [service we don't offer]. Respond helpfully and suggest alternatives if I can think of any."

Measuring Inquiry Performance

Key Metrics

Track these to optimize your system:

```
## Inquiry Metrics

### Volume
- Total inquiries per week/month
- Inquiries by category (Level 1/2/3)
- Inquiries by type (pricing, services, etc.)

### Response Time
- Average response time by level
- Percentage meeting target
- Worst case response times

### Outcomes
- Response-to-conversation rate
- Conversation-to-meeting rate
- Meeting-to-customer rate

### Automation Efficiency
- Percentage auto-responded (Level 1)
- Percentage AI-assisted (Level 2)
- Percentage human-led (Level 3)
- Time saved per inquiry
```

Weekly Review

“Give me a summary of this week’s inquiries. What patterns do you notice? What’s working? What needs improvement?”

```
📊 Weekly Inquiry Summary

## Volume
- Total inquiries: 47
- Level 1 (auto): 33 (70%)
- Level 2 (draft): 11 (23%)
- Level 3 (human): 3 (6%)

## Response Time
- Level 1 avg: 23 minutes ✓
- Level 2 avg: 2.3 hours ✓
- Level 3 avg: 5.2 hours ✓

## Patterns Noticed
- Pricing inquiries up 15% this week
- Several mentions of [competitor] in Level 2s
- 3 inquiries specifically about [new topic]

## Opportunities
- Consider adding FAQ for [new topic]
- May need comparison sheet for [competitor]
- Response templates working well

## Recommended Actions
1. Create template for [new topic] inquiries
2. Update comparison information
3. Review Level 2 drafts for personalization
```

Best Practices for Inquiry Automation

Start Conservative

1. Begin with clear FAQ auto-responses
2. Gradually expand to more complex inquiries
3. Always maintain human oversight for sensitive situations
4. Review AI responses regularly

Maintain Your Voice

- Templates should sound like you
- Customize drafts to add personality
- AI assists, you don't surrender your voice

Never Automate Empathy

- Complaints → Human
- Sensitive situations → Human
- High-value relationships → Human
- Anything unusual → Human

Keep Templates Updated

- Review templates monthly
- Update pricing and service information
- Incorporate what's working from human responses
- Remove outdated information

Track and Improve

- Monitor which responses convert
- Identify patterns in follow-up questions
- Refine templates based on outcomes
- Continuously improve your knowledge base

Coming Up Next

In Lesson 4.6, we'll bring everything together and build your first complete automation—the process for creating end-to-end automated workflows.

Key Takeaways

1. **Categorize inquiries by automation level** - Not all inquiries need the same response
2. **Templates save time, customization builds relationships** - Use both strategically
3. **Auto-respond to FAQs, assist with qualified leads, personally handle high-value** - Match effort to value
4. **Quality and speed both matter** - Fast responses that are also good responses
5. **Never automate empathy** - Some interactions require a human touch